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Words and the Dogon world

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 314

Culture (OWC): [Dogon \(FA16\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1946-1960

Coverage Date: 1946-1960

Place Coverage: Mopti Region, Mali

Section Title(S): Mending Bad Speech

Methods of repair differ according to the gravity of the offense and according to the personality of the offended party. One direct way to ask the pardon of someone you have offended is to reach for his ankles, saying mùyō kána, "excuse me" (literally: "have patience"). The word mùyō, "patience," is related to the verb mùyō, "to dip into water," thus to cool down, since in anger the heart is red and hot; to ask for pardon is like pouring cool water on a burning heart in order to pacify it. The gesture of immobilizing the ankles means that one shackles the offended party with words of atonement; he is then obliged to grant pardon. ⁶⁶

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Even so, it is rare that an offense between two people can be straightened out so directly. Usually a mediator is called in, either because the offender solicited his help in presenting excuses or because the mediator himself feels compelled to make the two opponents listen to reason. This mediating role in managing quarrels and "bad words" is particularly representative of Sudanese psychology. Society strives to avoid any accumulated bitterness between two of its members. The Dogon commonly say that a quarrel quickly righted is like a strip of fresh tree bark whose ends can be tied together because it is still supple. But after three days it is hard and dry and cannot be knotted without breaking; thus the quarrel which has "hardened" becomes worse until no one but the ancestors can repair it, a process that involves some risk (Part I, Chapter 6). The entire group, then, takes an interest in the relations of its members. Besides, it is well known that if one leaves the problem of reconciliation to the two quarreling parties there is a good chance that they will only harden in their attitudes, either from pride or from stubbornness. The intervention of the mediator, usually an older man whose word carries some weight (family chief, wise elder, blacksmith, or "joking relative"), causes the

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two parties to think about what is happening, to empty their hearts of bitterness and bad feelings, and 315 to think about the social consequences.⁶⁷

66. We are reminded of the symbolic allusion to shackles in the “speech of pardon” (the bark of the à: ála tree used to bind loads on donkeys), and also of the ancient gesture of supplication that consists of embracing the knees. It is possible that in both cases there is an appeal to the joints, seat of man's creative force. It is known that the **Dogon** give thanks by alluding to the number of joints in the human body.

67. The role of the intermediary is called s`[unavailable] yéguru, “arrangement of words.” It is also said “his speech puts cold on the head” of the two adversaries (s`[unavailable] kú:-n[unknown] kà:li: áá:s[unknown]), and also on their hearts which go from boiling to “cool” (kíne kà:li:).

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